Ukraine Peace Talks Resume in Abu Dhabi

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Negotiators from Ukraine, Russia, and the United States have begun new talks in Abu Dhabi aimed at ending the war in Ukraine. Expectations for a **breakthrough** are low, but American officials said Moscow and Kyiv were privately showing 'a little bit of flexibility' about who would control Ukraine's eastern regions after the war.

Jared Kushner, Donald Trump's son-in-law and part of the American delegation alongside peace **envoy** Steve Witkoff, said the talks would focus on the 'postwar security concerns' of both Russia and Ukraine. 'An important part of this process is encouraging all parties to begin thinking seriously about what comes after the war,' Kushner wrote.

The biggest **sticking point** is Donetsk, a region in eastern Ukraine now mostly controlled by Russia. Moscow has demanded Ukraine give up the parts it still holds, while Kyiv wants to freeze the contact line and keep those sections, which it says are crucial to its future security.

Neither side has budged in public, but an American official said the issue cannot be solved without first agreeing on a new 'security architecture' for after the war. For Ukraine, that could mean reassurance that allies would come to its aid if attacked again. For Russia, it could mean its longstanding wish to see NATO pull back from eastern Europe, a prospect that alarms Europeans.

The framework under discussion includes security consultations, crisis hotlines, and '**reciprocal** de-escalation measures.' Officials also raised restarting the NATO-Russia Council, largely paused since 2022. The last round of talks, in Geneva in February, ended without a **breakthrough**.

European leaders, who have largely been left out, have pushed to be involved. European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen urged that NATO allies and EU members be included, and the American side said it would propose bringing the Europeans into a wider format.

Word Treasure

negotiators -- People who talk with the other side to try to reach an agreement.

breakthrough -- A big step forward that solves a hard problem.

sticking point -- The hardest part of a disagreement, the thing the two sides cannot agree on.

envoy -- A person sent by a leader to talk with others on their behalf.

reciprocal -- Done by both sides in return for each other.

Background you need

Peace talks are meetings where the sides in a war try to agree on how to stop the fighting and what should happen afterwards.

In talks like these, each side often wants land, safety promises, and a say in what happens after the war, and the hardest question is usually who controls the disputed land.

Countries also talk about security, which means promises and plans to keep everyone safe after the fighting stops, such as help from allies if one side is attacked again.

Other countries that are not at the talks often still care about the result, because a deal can change safety for a whole region.

Break it down

LEAD: Negotiators from Ukraine, Russia, and the United States have begun new talks in Abu Dhabi aimed at ending the war in Ukraine.

KEY EVENT: Both sides are privately showing a little bit of flexibility about who would control Ukraine's eastern regions after the war, though expectations for a breakthrough are low.

+- WHO: Jared Kushner and peace envoy Steve Witkoff are part of the American delegation.

+- BIGGEST STICKING POINT: Donetsk, a region in eastern Ukraine now mostly controlled by Russia.

+- WHAT EACH SIDE WANTS: Moscow wants Ukraine to give up the parts it still holds; Kyiv wants to freeze the contact line and keep those sections.

EVIDENCE: The framework under discussion includes security consultations, crisis hotlines, and reciprocal de-escalation measures; officials also raised restarting the NATO-Russia Council, largely paused since 2022.

OPEN QUESTION: Whether the sides can agree on a new security architecture for after the war, and whether European leaders will be brought into a wider format.

Why it matters

The talks could shape how the war in Ukraine ends and how safe Europe is afterwards, so what is decided in Abu Dhabi matters far beyond the meeting room.

Test what you remember

1. Where did the new talks begin?

- (A) Moscow
- (B) Geneva
- (C) Kyiv
- (D) Abu Dhabi

2. What do American officials say both sides are privately showing?

- (A) A plan to end the war this week
- (B) A little bit of flexibility about who controls eastern Ukraine
- (C) A wish to stop talking
- (D) A new trade deal

3. What is the biggest sticking point?

- (A) The European Commission
- (B) The city of Abu Dhabi
- (C) Donetsk, a region in eastern Ukraine now mostly controlled by Russia
- (D) The NATO-Russia Council

4. What does Moscow want Ukraine to do?

- (A) Freeze the contact line
- (B) Join NATO at once
- (C) Give up the parts of Donetsk it still holds
- (D) Leave the talks in Abu Dhabi

5. What is in the framework under discussion?

- (A) A trade deal with the European Union
- (B) A plan to rebuild Abu Dhabi
- (C) Security consultations, crisis hotlines, and reciprocal de-escalation measures
- (D) A new space program

6. What happened at the last round of talks in Geneva in February?

- (A) They ended without a breakthrough
- (B) They moved the talks to Kyiv
- (C) They agreed on who controls Donetsk
- (D) They ended the war

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: C 4: C 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The American side: Says both sides are privately showing a little bit of flexibility and that the issue cannot be solved without first agreeing on a new security architecture for after the war.

2. Moscow: Has demanded Ukraine give up the parts of Donetsk it still holds, and has long wanted NATO to pull back from eastern Europe.

3. Kyiv: Wants to freeze the contact line and keep the sections of Donetsk it still holds, which it says are crucial to its future security.

4. European leaders: Have largely been left out of the talks and have pushed to be involved; European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen urged that NATO allies and EU members be included.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):